2. We may need to know who a user is to decide what they can do, to enforce confidentiality and integrity goals.
3. We may want to only process authenticated requests to avoid anonymous DoS attacks that compromise availability.

As authentication is the most common method of identifying a user, it is common to talk of “authenticating a user” as a shorthand for identifying that user via authentication. In reality, we never “authenticate” a user themselves but rather *claims* about their identity such as their username. To authenticate a claim simply means to determine if it is authentic, or genuine. This is usually achieved by asking the user to present some kind of *credentials* that prove that the claims are correct (they provide *credence* to the claims, which is where the word “credential” comes from), such as providing a password along with the username that only that user would know.

There are many ways of authenticating a user, which can be divided into three broad categories known as authentication *factors*:

- Something you know, such as a secret password.
- Something you have, like a key or physical device.
- Something you are. This refers to biometric factors, such as your unique fingerprint or iris pattern.

Any individual factor of authentication may be compromised. People chose weak passwords or write them down on notes attached to their computer screen, and they